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From the editor-in-chief

All of this year, the news from Pakistan has been extremely alarming and has only got worse. Terrorists have been running amok in the country and most recently there were attacks at the heart of the country's army headquarters in Rawalpindi. In fact, it is estimated there have been 300 terrorist attacks in two years, killing as many as 2,500 people. Along with the brazen attack on the army headquarters, bomb blasts and suicide attacks have taken place in Lahore, Peshawar, Islamabad and other smaller towns. The targets have been busy markets, five-star hotels, university campuses and bustling centres of urban life. There seems to be a violent incident every week and the death toll keeps mounting. Pakistan is at war within, under siege and in desperate trouble as a nation.

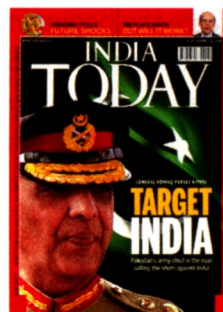
It is the Pakistan Taliban which is responsible for these attacks in response to the army's operations to drive them away from south Waziristan. They seem to be able to strike at will and the Pakistan Government too appears incapable of preventing them from doing so. What these horrific events have now led to is a dangerous political rift between President Asif Zardari's Government and the military top brass. The army is unimpressed by Zardari's functioning and getting more restless as the attacks continue. Nine years of military rule under General Pervez Musharraf also means that the army is unlikely to kowtow to the civilian government or have any respect for it. It could now well want to seize power and of course, Zardari would not want to surrender it.

The province of Balochistan is also simmering; the economy is in a shambles and a country which has only just returned to democracy and an elected government is on the brink of collapse. Pakistan's impending disintegration threatens not just its own civil society but also the rest of the world. It is not called the most dangerous place in the world for nothing. Today, Pakistan has become the new breeding ground of the Islamist terrorist while also being a nuclear power with a weak government. All this is a most lethal cocktail.

Our cover story this week is on whether Pakistan can be saved and why it actually needs to be. Our man in Karachi, Hasan Zaidi, reveals how seriously close the country is to collapse, the tug of war between Zardari and the army and talks about the options now available to civil society and the political class. We also look whether a reconciliation between political enemies like Nawaz Sharif and Zardari is possible, whether civil society and the judiciary can play a role and the impact that the developments in Pakistan could have on India.

Whatever India may think of Pakistan, it is important that our neighbour does not implode and become a country with an internal situation like Afghanistan. The collapse of an elected government is actually detrimental to India. The last thing we need is our troublesome neighbour with loose nukes ruled either by its military or constantly struggling against the Taliban.

(Aroon Purie)



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